

D698

Elementary Disciplinary Literacy

Armored Drill

8 concepts · 12 items · 4 transfer items

What this is. Every concept in this course's public description, re-asked with more disguise than a practice test uses. Each stem carries facts that do not decide it. Every wrong answer is a named trap.

Source. Scope from the course's public description in the WGU Institutional Catalog (September 2026); items written from the field's standard body of knowledge. No WGU assessment item, course material or proprietary content is used or reproduced. Not affiliated with or endorsed by Western Governors University.

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How to run it

Paper first. Pencil. One pass, no notes, a timer if you want the pressure.

1. **Before you read the options**, fill the strip under the item: the target word (what is actually being asked), and the one fact in the stem that decides it.
2. **Principle before arithmetic**. Name the rule, then compute.
3. **Camouflage**. Most of every stem does not matter. Ask: which single fact decides this?
4. **Inverse pairs are the bait**. If two options are opposites, one of them is the trap built for you.
5. **Mark sure, unsure or guess** honestly. Sure-and-wrong is the most valuable miss on the page — it is a wrong mental model.
6. **Absolutes** (always, never, guarantee) are usually wrong. And recognizing an answer is not the same as owning it.
7. Items with a **heavy black bar** on the left are **transfer items**: the same principle, reversed or solved for a different variable.
8. Stop at the STOP page. Then grade, fill the triage grid, and tally the traps you fell for. The biggest tally is what you drill next.

The strip, filled in, looks like this:

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	_____	

Items

1.

In a fifth-grade science unit on ecosystems, a teacher whose class has a pet fish asks students to compare an article's data table to their own pond-water observations and note where the evidence agrees or conflicts, as scientists do. The class uses tablets donated by a local business. What kind of literacy instruction is this?

- A. Digital literacy, because tablets are used.
- B. Foundational literacy (decoding).
- C. Disciplinary literacy.
- D. Content-area literacy.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

2. [TRANSFER — reversed stem / different variable]

Which activity is content-area literacy rather than disciplinary literacy?

- A. Using a KWL chart before reading a social studies chapter.
- B. Checking who created a historical photograph and why.
- C. Any reading done in a science or history class.
- D. Writing a lab conclusion that ties data to a science principle.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

3.

Fourth graders read a letter written in 1850 by a gold-rush miner to his family, praising how easy it was to get rich. The letter is displayed in a glass case at the town museum, which the class visited in October. What should the teacher ask first to build historical thinking?

- A. "How much gold did miners find?"
- B. "Why do museums keep letters in glass cases?"
- C. "Since it is from 1850, what does it prove about the gold rush?"
- D. "Who wrote this, to whom, and why might he describe it that way?"

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

4. [TRANSFER — reversed stem / different variable]

Students have sourced a newspaper account of a strike. Next they compare it with a factory owner’s diary and a worker’s interview. Which historical thinking skill are they using now?

- A.** Corroboration
- B.** Contextualization
- C.** Summarizing
- D.** Sourcing

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

5.

Third graders on the school’s garden team grew bean plants, some in sunlight and some in a closet. A student writes: “Plants need light to grow. The plants in the window grew 12 cm and the closet plants grew 3 cm.” The seeds were bought at a hardware store. What is missing from the explanation?

- A.** Evidence.
- B.** Reasoning: why light matters, such as plants using light to make food.
- C.** Where the seeds came from.
- D.** A claim.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

6.

A word problem reads: “Find the product of 6 and 4.” A student who is new to the school and loves cooking answers “a cake.” Several classmates laugh. What is the best instructional response?

- A.** Address the laughter and move on.
- B.** Explicitly teach that in math, product means the result of multiplying, and contrast it with the everyday meaning.
- C.** Tell the student to read more carefully.
- D.** Assume the student cannot multiply.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

7.

A fifth-grade passage on the Dust Bowl, which the class is reading during a unit that ends with a field trip, says: "Farmers plowed up grasses. As a result, soil blew away when drought came, and so thousands of families left." Which graphic organizer best fits?

- A. A timeline, since it is history.
- B. A Venn diagram.
- C. A cause-and-effect chain.
- D. A problem/solution chart, since every history text is problem/solution.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

8. [TRANSFER — reversed stem / different variable]

A teacher wants students to write a paragraph with a compare-and-contrast structure about frogs and toads. Which signal words should she teach?

- A. because, as a result, therefore
- B. the problem is, one solution
- C. first, next, finally
- D. both, similarly, however, unlike

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

9.

A student researching volcanoes in a hardcover book with a shiny cover wants to find every page that mentions magma. The book has 96 pages. Which text feature should she use?

- A. The index.
- B. The table of contents.
- C. Page through all 96 pages.
- D. The glossary.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

10.

A fourth-grade teacher, whose class won the school spelling bee, is starting a weather unit with the words thermometer, thermal, and thermostat. What is the most efficient vocabulary approach?

- A.** Assign the words as spelling words only.
- B.** Have students memorize each definition separately.
- C.** Teach the root therm (heat) and have students use it to explain all three words.
- D.** Teach the suffix -meter first, since all three words end in it.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

11.

Fifth graders researching whether a sports drink helps kids learn find a colorful website with charts, a .org address, and a “Science” tab. The class has library time on Fridays. What should the teacher coach them to do first?

- A.** Trust it because it has a .org address.
- B.** Open a new tab and search who runs the site and what others say about it.
- C.** Trust it because it has charts and a Science tab.
- D.** Read the whole site carefully to judge it.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

12. [TRANSFER — reversed stem / different variable]

A student learns that the sports drink website is run by the company that sells the drink. What should the student conclude?

- A.** The site is reliable because the company knows its product best.
- B.** The site is reliable if it has a .org address.
- C.** Everything on the site is false.
- D.** The site may be biased, so check its claims against independent sources.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

STOP

Answers and dissection follow. Finish every item and every strip first.

Key and dissection

Struck-through text is the camouflage: facts that do not decide the item.

1. Answer C Concept 1

In a fifth-grade science unit on ecosystems, a teacher ~~whose class has a pet fish~~ asks students to compare an article's data table to their own pond-water observations and note where the evidence agrees or conflicts, as scientists do. ~~The class uses tablets donated by a local business.~~ What kind of literacy instruction is this?

Target word: classify the instruction **Decides:** Evaluating evidence against data is how scientists read.

A	Camouflage	The device does not define the literacy practice.
B	Adjacent category	The task is not about word reading.
C	Correct	It teaches a practice specific to how scientists read and weigh evidence.
D	Confusion set	Content-area literacy uses general strategies that work in any subject.

2. Answer A Concept 1 • transfer

Which activity is content-area literacy rather than disciplinary literacy?

Target word: pick the general strategy — reverse **Decides:** A strategy that works the same in any subject.

A	Correct	KWL is a general strategy, used the same way in any subject.
B	Inverted operation	Sourcing is a historian's practice: disciplinary.
C	Absolute language	The subject alone does not decide the type.
D	Adjacent category	CER writing is a scientist's practice: disciplinary.

3. Answer D Concept 2

Fourth graders read a letter written in 1850 by a gold-rush miner to his family, praising how easy it was to get rich. The letter is ~~displayed in a glass case at the town museum, which the class visited in October.~~ What should the teacher ask first to build historical thinking?

Target word: first historical-thinking question **Decides:** Sourcing: who wrote it and why.

A	Dropped element	Drops sourcing and treats the letter as fact.
B	Camouflage	The display detail does not bear on historical thinking.
C	Absolute language	Being from the time does not make it true.
D	Correct	Sourcing is the first move in reading a primary source.

4. Answer A Concept 2 • transfer

Students have sourced a newspaper account of a strike. Next they compare it with a factory owner's diary and a worker's interview. Which historical thinking skill are they using now?

Target word: name the skill **Decides:** Comparing across sources is corroboration.

A	Correct	Checking sources against each other is corroboration.
B	Confusion set	Contextualization places a source in its time; it is not comparing sources.
C	Adjacent category	A general strategy, not the historian's cross-check.
D	Wrong stem number	Sourcing is the step they already completed.

5. Answer B Concept 3

Third graders ~~on the school's garden team~~ grew bean plants, some in sunlight and some in a closet. A student writes: "Plants need light to grow. The plants in the window grew 12 cm and the closet plants grew 3 cm." ~~The seeds were bought at a hardware store.~~ What is missing from the explanation?

Target word: missing CER part **Decides:** Claim and evidence are present; no science principle links them.

A	Confusion set	The growth measurements are evidence.
B	Correct	Reasoning connects evidence to claim with a science principle.
C	Camouflage	Seed source is irrelevant to the explanation.
D	Dropped element	"Plants need light to grow" is the claim.

6. Answer B Concept 4

A word problem reads: "Find the product of 6 and 4." A student ~~who is new to the school and loves cooking~~ answers "a cake." ~~Several classmates laugh.~~ What is the best instructional response?

Target word: best response **Decides:** An everyday word has a special math meaning.

A	Camouflage	Classroom climate matters, but it does not fix the word meaning.
B	Correct	Multiple-meaning math words need direct teaching.
C	Dropped element	Drops the vocabulary instruction that caused the error.
D	Adjacent category	The error is vocabulary, not computation.

7. Answer C Concept 5

A fifth-grade passage on the Dust Bowl, ~~which the class is reading during a unit that ends with a field trip~~, says: "Farmers plowed up grasses. As a result, soil blew away when drought came, and so thousands of families left." Which graphic organizer best fits?

Target word: structure **Decides:** "As a result" and "so" signal cause and effect.

A	Adjacent category	Chooses the structure by topic, not by signal words.
B	Confusion set	Venn diagrams fit compare/contrast.
C	Correct	The signal words show causes leading to effects.
D	Absolute language	No solution is given; not every history text uses that structure.

8. Answer D Concept 5 • transfer

A teacher wants students to write a paragraph with a compare-and-contrast structure about frogs and toads. Which signal words should she teach?

Target word: signal words for a given structure — reverse **Decides:** Compare/contrast uses words showing likeness and difference.

A	Confusion set	Cause-and-effect signal words.
B	Inverted operation	Problem/solution signal words; no problem is being solved.
C	Adjacent category	Sequence signal words.
D	Correct	These signal likenesses and differences.

9. Answer A Concept 6

A student researching volcanoes in a hardcover book ~~with a shiny cover~~ wants to find every page that mentions magma. ~~The book has 96 pages.~~ Which text feature should she use?

Target word: feature for locating a topic **Decides:** Finding pages on a topic is the index's job.

A	Correct	The index lists topics with page numbers.
B	Adjacent category	It lists chapters, not every mention of a term.
C	Camouflage	Uses the page count detail instead of the right feature.
D	Confusion set	The glossary defines words; it does not list pages.

10. Answer C Concept 7

A fourth-grade teacher, ~~whose class won the school spelling bee,~~ is starting a weather unit with the words thermometer, thermal, and thermostat. What is the most efficient vocabulary approach?

Target word: most efficient approach **Decides:** The shared root therm (heat).

A	Camouflage	Follows the spelling-bee detail; spelling is not meaning.
B	Dropped element	Drops the shared root that makes learning efficient.
C	Correct	Morphology unlocks a family of words at once.
D	Wrong stem number	Only thermometer ends in -meter.

11. Answer B Concept 8

Fifth graders researching whether a sports drink helps kids learn find a colorful website with charts, a .org address, and a "Science" tab. ~~The class has library time on Fridays.~~ What should the teacher coach them to do first?

Target word: first evaluation move **Decides:** Look up who runs the site from outside sources.

A	Absolute language	Anyone can register a .org.
B	Correct	Lateral reading checks the source from outside it.
C	Adjacent category	Looks are design features, not credibility.
D	Inverted operation	Staying on the page (vertical reading) is what fact-checkers avoid.

12. Answer D Concept 8 • transfer

A student learns that the sports drink website is run by the company that sells the drink. What should the student conclude?

Target word: conclusion after lateral reading **Decides:** The source has a financial interest.

A	Inverted operation	Treats the conflict of interest as a strength.
B	Confusion set	Domain does not decide credibility.
C	Absolute language	Bias means verify, not that every claim is wrong.
D	Correct	A seller's interest calls for corroboration.

Triage grid

Write each item number in the box it belongs to.

	Right	Wrong
Sure	Owned.	Concept inversion — top priority. A wrong mental model; it survives rewording.
Unsure / guess	Recognition, not mastery. Re-drill with the transfer.	Not learned yet.

Trap tally

For every miss, find the letter you chose in the key and tally its trap. The biggest number is the pattern to drill.

Trap	What it does	In this drill	Your misses
Dropped element	Leaves out a required term or step.	4	
Wrong stem number	A figure copied from the prompt that is not the answer.	2	
Adjacent category	The right idea in the wrong bucket.	8	
Inverted operation	Direction flipped: add/subtract, cause/effect, higher/lower.	4	
Absolute language	Always, never, guarantee — where judgment applies.	5	
Confusion set	Every option is real; the test is exact role-matching.	7	
Camouflage	Answers a stem fact that was never the question.	6	

Anchor rows — the concept list

One row per concept: the rule to lock in, the trap that catches people, and the tell in the question that signals it.

#	Concept	Rule	Trap	Tell
1	Disciplinary vs. content-area literacy	Content-area literacy applies general strategies (summarizing, predicting) to any text; disciplinary literacy teaches how experts in a field read, write, and argue.	Thinking a general strategy used in science class is disciplinary literacy.	Whether the practice would be the same in every subject.
2	Reading like a historian	Historians source (who wrote it, when, why), contextualize (what was happening then), and corroborate (compare with other sources).	Treating a primary source as automatically true because it is from the time.	A diary, letter, or poster from the past.
3	Claim-Evidence-Reasoning in science	A scientific explanation states a claim, backs it with data as evidence, and uses reasoning (a science principle) to link them.	Mistaking a restatement of the data or an opinion for reasoning.	A student explanation of an investigation.
4	Precise and multiple-meaning words in math	Math text is dense and exact; everyday words take special meanings (product, table, volume, difference, odd), so they must be taught explicitly.	Assuming students know a math word because they use it in daily life.	A familiar word used in a math problem.
5	Informational text structures	Structures (description, sequence, compare/contrast, cause/effect, problem/solution) are signaled by words like because/as a result, however/both, first/then, and help readers organize ideas.	Naming the structure from the topic instead of the signal words and organization.	Signal words and a graphic organizer choice.
6	Text features and their purpose	Each feature serves a job: headings organize, captions explain images, glossaries define, indexes locate topics, diagrams show parts or processes.	Using the glossary to find where a topic appears, or the index to get a definition.	“Where can I find...?” vs. “What does ... mean?”
7	Morphology for academic vocabulary	Teaching Greek and Latin roots and affixes (photo, graph, therm, -ology) unlocks many content words at once.	Teaching each science word as an isolated item to memorize.	A set of related content words sharing a part.
8	Evaluating online sources (lateral reading)	Check who is behind a site by leaving it and searching what others say about the source, rather than judging by how it looks.	Trusting a site because it looks professional or ends in .org.	Students researching online.

Course scope (public description): Elementary Disciplinary Literacy is an innovative course designed for candidates seeking to deepen their understanding and application of literacy skills within specific academic disciplines. This course focuses on the unique literacy demands of content disciplines, exploring how reading, writing, speaking, and listening are used differently in each domain. Students investigate the specialized language structures and text features inherent to each discipline and learn strategies to help learners navigate and master these complexities. The curriculum emphasizes the development of skills through the science of reading that

enable candidates to guide learners in critically engaging with and producing disciplinary texts. Candidates also explore ways to integrate technology and digital literacy into their teaching practices, enhancing students' ability to access, interpret, and share discipline-specific information. Through a blend of research-based evidence and authentic learning activities using structured literacy practices, this course aims to give educators the skills needed to effectively teach disciplinary literacy, thereby improving student achievement and content understanding across all areas of study.